> First you find a person who can match you and sit (on the throne) in your place, and then come for this work…remember God. Kingship does not prevent you from remembering Him.

The Mughal camp continued towards Kumaon, and could now see ‘the snow-covered Himalaya mountains…gleaming white’, while a cold wind blew over the fluttering standards of the army. ‘The Hindus who inhabited Kumaon,’ wrote Monserrate, ‘do not own allegiance to [Akbar] and are protected by exceedingly thick forests.’ At Kalanaur, where he had been proclaimed Padshah twenty-five years previously, Akbar stayed in the gardens which he had had planted all those decades ago. The Mughal camp slowly passed through plains and glens, fragrant in the cool air, and crossed rushing streams filled with the flickering movement of fish and lethal crocodiles. Rivers were crossed either by constructing wooden bridges, or by lashing boats together with grass ropes and laying branches on them to make a temporary, bobbing construction. Akbar was insistent about the army crossing carefully in single file so that no confusion was caused with ‘the cavalry, the infantry, the camels, the baggage-animals, the flocks and the herds’ crossing together. Monserrate was impressed with Akbar’s meticulous attention to detail and concern for the soldiery, writing that ‘praise should be given to [Akbar]’s carefulness and foresight in giving such earnest attention to the safety of his army that he consulted its interests not only in the matter of water supply and of cheap corn, but also in the passage of rivers’.

In the evenings, stories were told or religion discussed with the Jesuits and Brahmin priests. Conspicuous by his absence on this carefully planned journey was Badauni. Caught up, by his own admission, in a ‘bond of friendship’ for a youth called ‘Mazhar’ which so distracted him, he was absent from court for an unforgivable period of a year. Badauni, even seventeen years after the event, did not regret the illicit passion which caused him such dereliction of duty. ‘The delight of that taste,’ he bravely proclaimed, ‘has never left my heart.’ Akbar was considerably less impressed with his unpredictable scholar. ‘How was he left behind on this journey?’ the Padshah enquired of Abu’l Fazl angrily, and excuses of ill-health had to be quickly invented to save Badauni from being struck off permanently from the royal rolls. Badauni’s dereliction of duty by not attending to the Padshah was a much more serious crime than it may appear to be. Personal attendance by courtiers, when Akbar commanded it, was